

AN ANGRY PEOPLE
A Jat protest for reservations at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, Mar. 2, 2017

1970s—Nitish's new proposal for raising overall quotas to 75 per cent will proportionately benefit them. Even Gujarat has 32 rows for Muslim OBCs who, as Modi acknowledged in a 2022 interview, "used to get benefits" when he was CM.

THE CASTE CATALYST

It was a series of contingent events that brought the Congress to the helm of a caste-based campaign. Once Nitish's caste survey confirmed that non-elite castes constituted an overwhelming 84.5 per cent of Bihar's teeming demography, other states picked up the baton by either conducting, promising or contemplating a similar survey—Odisha, Karnataka, Telangana, Maharashtra. A chorus started building up on the need for a nationwide caste census, and once Nitish plotted his own exit from centre stage, the Congress stepped into the vacuum. Moily, though, says: "The language Rahul is using is a mistake. Mixing it with ideas like wealth redistribution is not correct, it's not the Congress way." He advocates a more evolutionist approach.

Unlike issues where it was free to be both blunt and sharp, this was slippery turf for the BJP—saying yes would subvert the RSS idea of a 'united Hinduism', abjuring it could be injurious to electoral health. In the event, it chose feint over thrust: after a 2018 statement by defence minister Rajnath Singh that caste would be part of the 2021 census, the party retracted; then Covid interrupted, and the main decennial census itself was missed. All this had a backing track: in 2017, the Centre had set up the Rohini Commission to study the uneven concentration of benefits within OBC castes and to suggest segmented quotas. After 13 extensions, it submitted a report in July 2023—but went straight into the chiller compartment as the atmosphere outside heated up on the issue.

Not everyone in the Opposition is conclusively on board. Mamata's early silence on the issue, for one, was deafening—though she later took to invoking the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) as a "threat to quotas". Though Trinamool Congress leaders deny it, she's reported to have walked out of an INDIA meeting in September because the caste census was being brought up—apparently causing it to be dropped from the subsequent political resolution. A focus on caste is an unwanted complication for Mamata's nativist, pro-minority politics. But Bengal is changing. The state's OBC ratio is now estimated at 60 per cent—Mandal had said 40 per cent—and SC/STs account for another 29 per cent. So, that "90 per cent" is no metaphor. And Mamata is adjusting, setting up community-specific development boards, and is often heard using the Santhal greeting 'Jai Johar'.

Maharashtra, meanwhile, saw the gathering storm clouds create a point of aggravation: a sub-plot around a demand for Maratha reservations, and a counter-mobilisation of OBCs. Though its protagonists receded as mysteriously as they arrived, the issue is alive to some degree. "In reality," says Palshikar, "caste blocs had generally fragmented in Maharashtra over the past decade owing to competitive politics; this applies across Dalits, Marathas and OBCs. There is no one-to-one correspondence between Caste X and Party X. Among Marathas, that fragmentation is more acute because of the two party splits. So, it has come down to the constituency level, where the caste/reservations vs Hindutva dilemma is often settled by who the candidate is."

The older Mandal parties up north are, paradoxically, trying to shed that one-to-one correspondence. Akhilesh Yadav now cultivates a 'PDA' social alliance: the 'D' (for Dalit) occupies the centre among Pichhdas and Adivasis. Tejashwi Yadav tells his rally crowds to "be nice to others"; his RJD spouts an assimilative "A to Z" language. Both seek to grow out of the old "Yadav party" tag. Winning over the EBCs, with their past baggage, is the core of their present electoral struggle. Besides those of his family, Akhilesh has largely kept Yadavs out of his candidate list, preferring EBCs and Dalits. His partnership with the Congress, newly attractive with its Mandal Plus vocabulary, may also help.

For the 'national' parties, caste can no longer be taken as an interruption on the normal order of things. No longer is it the fine print of politics. To be dealt with in the dark, or on the margins of its main text. The reservation question yanks it to centre stage. Will it work electorally? Regardless of which side wins on June 4, it seems near-certain that the theme will leave a mark on policy—and the polity. ■

with inputs from **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Vipul Grover**